sessions to keep a record of what I had to go through. I was due to undergo three sessions but I urged the doctor to administer a fourth one if he thought it would help me get fit quicker. Anjali's presence had given me the courage to press on with the recovery and I was desperate to get fit, particularly for the Test series against Australia. Seeing my desperation, one of the doctors asked me how important that series was for me and why I was so determined to play. I said that it would be like missing my own wedding reception and there was no way I would want to do that!

Despite all my efforts, I was in no condition to take part in the Champions Trophy and I also had to miss the first two Tests against Australia. It was extremely frustrating to be forced to sit out and watch Clarke and Gilchrist score centuries to set up a 217-run victory for Australia in the first Test at Bangalore, despite eleven wickets in the game for Harbhajan Singh. I even had a steroid injection on the eve of the second Test match in Chennai, but it didn't work. The Chennai Test was a draw and then finally, after two weeks of complete rest, the pain had subsided enough for me to return for the third Test at Nagpur on 26 October 2004. It wasn't the greatest comeback match. On a seaming pitch, Gillespie took nine wickets and Damien Martyn just missed out on a century in both innings, as Australia won by 342 runs. My contribution was a disappointing total of ten runs.

In the final Test at the Wankhede Stadium the following week, Rahul and I were at the crease in the second innings when all of a sudden I felt a searing pain in my elbow again. It was at a critical stage in a low-scoring match and I was worried that I had rushed the comeback and was going to let my team down. I immediately asked for some painkillers and, thinking to myself that it would have an instant effect, decided to chew up two tablets rather than gulping them down. Gritting my teeth, I dug in and managed to battle my way to 55. With Laxman scoring a brilliant 69, we set Australia a target of 107 in the fourth innings. Helped by another five-wicket haul from Harbhajan and three from the left-arm spinner Murali Kartik, who was the Player of the Match, we proceeded to bowl Australia out for just 93 and won the match by 13 runs. The pain was definitely worth it. Unfortunately for Kartik, he did not get another chance to play Test cricket for India after that.

We followed the Australia series with two home Tests against South Africa in November 2004. The first at Kanpur was a draw, but the